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WashU Neuroscience Academic Innovation Navigator: Ecosystem Map and App-Spec Research Report

Executive summary

Washington University has a **strong but fragmented innovation ecosystem**. The university already has most of the ingredients needed to move a neuroscience discovery from laboratory observation to grant-funded validation, IP protection, licensing, startup formation, therapeutic development, industry partnership, and clinical translation. OTM provides the core technology-transfer and new-venture infrastructure; the Gap Fund and Domain Expert Program address de-risking; Skandalaris provides venture education and advising; the Needleman Program targets therapeutic development; ICTS and the Hope Center provide translational research infrastructure and funding; the Neurotech Hub provides technical development capability; and WashU has built structured industry relationships such as VeritaScience/Deerfield and the new Bristol Myers Squibb neuroscience collaboration. Regionally, BioSTL/BioGenerator, Cortex, Arch Grants, Missouri Technology Corporation, Missouri SBDC, and several life-science investors add capital, company-building, mentoring, space, and SBIR/STTR support. [1]

The problem is not primarily a shortage of programs. It is that **the ecosystem is organized around organizations and mechanisms rather than the investigator's goals**. WashU Innovation's institutional process is organized as Identify → Evaluate → Connect → Support → Communicate, while OTM, Skandalaris, ICTS, Needleman and external organizations each present their own resource menus. That is sensible administratively but leaves a neuroscientist to answer, often without guidance, “Which of these matters to me, when, and why?” [2]

The navigator should therefore not reproduce another program directory. Its fundamental data model should be:

> **motivation → desired outcome → current state → missing evidence → possible vehicles → appropriate resources → next action**

A patent, SBIR, license or startup is normally a **vehicle**, not the investigator's ultimate destination. For example, “I want this device to reach patients, but I do not want to run a company” should route toward OTM evaluation, external validation, translational de-risking, regulatory planning and potentially licensing—not automatically entrepreneurship. Conversely, “I want funding to keep an engineer in my laboratory and generate the next dataset” may route toward ICTS, the Gap Fund, NIH translational programs or an industry collaboration without ever requiring company formation.

Six destination outcomes are recommended for the MVP: **clinical use, licensing, startup/company, research impact, funding, and distribution/adoption**. Ten readiness states can then describe where the inventor currently is, independently of where they hope to go. This avoids the misleading Idea → Patent → Startup sequence.

Several eligibility rules make automated routing particularly valuable. The WashU Gap Fund is aimed at promising **non-drug** WashU technologies, whereas Needleman specifically seeks promising **therapeutic candidates** and its currently posted application window is closed. [3] Skandalaris's Venture Competition is especially easy to mis-route: its current rules require qualifying student/recent-alumni participation and explicitly prohibit WashU IP or a license to WashU or other university IP. [4] Arch Grants requires the company to establish headquarters in St. Louis for at least a year and currently requires at least one founder to work on the company as their primary/full-time role; its 2026 application cycle is already closed. [5] NIH SBIR/STTR funding requires an eligible U.S. small business rather than an academic laboratory acting alone, while STTR is explicitly structured around small-business/research-institution collaboration. [6]

The most useful navigator therefore needs **eligibility gates and negative routing**, not merely recommendations:

> "This looks relevant, but you are not eligible yet."
>
> "You do not need a startup for this."
>
> "This program is for therapeutics; your device should go elsewhere."
>
> "This competition explicitly excludes your WashU-licensed IP."
>
> "The current application cycle is closed, but this is a likely future milestone."

Program status also needs a `last_verified` field. As of **September 4, 2026**, for example, NPIC publicly says applications are closed; Arch Grants' 2026 competition is closed; the first announced Bristol Myers Squibb neuroscience expression-of-interest deadline was September 1, 2026; and the ICTS 2026 CTRFP LOI stage has passed even though invited applications have a September 14 deadline. [7]

For a first MVP, the strongest twelve cards are: **OTM/Core Tech Transfer, Domain Expert Program, Gap Fund, Experts-in-Residence, OTM New Ventures/EIR, Neurotech Hub, Hope Center, ICTS Research Forum + translational funding, Needleman, Skandalaris Venture Development, BioGenerator, and NIH/NINDS + Missouri SBIR support**. Dynamic partner opportunities such as VeritaScience and the Bristol Myers Squibb neuroscience collaboration should be surfaced as secondary/context-sensitive cards.

A useful product-level principle follows from this research:

> **The navigator should optimize for the investigator's desired academic return—not for the number of patents or startups generated.**

That means explicitly modeling publications, preliminary data and grants, trainee/staff support, collaborations, scientific reach, patient impact, entrepreneurial learning, sponsored research, licensing income and possible startup equity as different forms of return.

Ecosystem resource catalog

The following catalog is a **September 4, 2026 snapshot** of programs that are materially relevant to neuroscience invention and translation. “Unspecified” means the detail could not be established from a current public official source; the app should preserve that state rather than infer it.

WashU resources

Resource	Useful when	What you get	Investigator benefit / what you do *not* need to do	Eligibility and status	Contact / l step / offic
WashU Innovation	You do not know where in the university ecosystem you belong.	University-wide roadmap and directory spanning commercialization, education, funding and space. WashU describes its innovation process as Identify → Evaluate → Connect → Support → Communicate. [8]	Orientation and discovery of programs; **no company or disclosure is required merely to explore the ecosystem**.	General WashU ecosystem resource.	Next: rout funding, entrepren translation Official [9]
OTM — invention disclosure, evaluation, IP and licensing	Something developed in the lab may have utility outside it, or an investigator wants to preserve transfer/ commercialization options.	Disclosure intake, evaluation, patent/IP strategy, marketing/ licensing and commercialization support. The disclosure requests an invention description, creators, funding and related information. [10]	Lets the investigator understand transfer options without deciding to become an entrepreneur. **A startup is not required.**	WashU inventions; assignment/ contact depends on academic unit. OTM's department lookup explicitly includes neuroscience-related units. [11]	`otm@wus` 314-747-1 Duncan Av Next: evalu strategy – risking/sta pathway.

Resource	Useful when	What you get	Investigator benefit / what you do *not* need to do	Eligibility and status	Contact / l step / offic
OTM Domain Expert Program — DEP	Technology works scientifically, but the team does not know what industry, regulatory, product-development or investor evidence matters next.	Curated sector-specific industry/investor feedback and actionable recommendations about commercial potential and de-risking. OTM reports DEP panels have been used to connect projects onward to resources including the Gap Fund. [13]	Can prevent the lab from spending scarce research time on development milestones that outsiders do not value. **You do not need to already know the market or have a startup team.**	OTM-mediated selection/referral; complete researcher-facing public eligibility criteria are **unspecified**.	Start with technolog Next: valic Gap Fund, conversati or venture [Official] [1
Washington University Gap Fund	A specific non-drug experiment, prototype or development milestone would meaningfully increase the technology's transfer/commercial value.	Translational funding for promising **non-drug WashU technologies**. Current OTM information says commitments are made in blocks up to **$55,000** and technically no overall maximum is stated. [15]	Pays for work conventional academic grants may not prioritize but that can de-risk a technology. **You do not need to start a company.**	WashU non-drug technologies; project selection through OTM. Additional detailed selection criteria/timing should be treated as program-specific.	OTM, `otm@wus` Next: com milestone evaluate w licensees/ [Official] [1
OTM Experts-in-Residence — XiR	The project needs experienced external judgment or domain knowledge rather than general business instruction.	Access to experienced expertise within the OTM innovation network. OTM publishes XiR eligibility/requirements for participating experts; expert participation itself is invitation-only. [17]	Investigator does not have to independently locate every expert.	Researcher-facing routing criteria are **unspecified publicly**; access should be treated as OTM-mediated.	Start with use expert define pro technical c milestone

Resource	Useful when	What you get	Investigator benefit / what you do *not* need to do	Eligibility and status	Contact / I step / offic
OTM Entrepreneur-in-Residence — EIR / New Ventures	A startup is becoming a plausible vehicle and the scientific founders need experienced company-building help.	Founder coaching, business-case/ value-proposition refinement, business-model work and startup mentoring. The EIR program is administered through New Ventures. [18]	Faculty can explore company formation without personally having all CEO/ business-development expertise. **Startup intent is relevant, however; this is not the default path for every disclosed invention.**	OTM states that the research team's WashU patent must be foundational to the startup license; EIR connection is at New Ventures' discretion. [19]	Karen Ghe PhD, Direc Ventures, 314-747-0 shown by `mullis@` Next: start license, fir [Official](#) [20
OTM Quick Start License	A qualifying WashU-IP startup is ready to license foundational university patent rights and standardized terms could reduce negotiation burden.	Standardized startup license. Current public terms include **no WashU equity** and a fixed **2% patent royalty on product sales**, with additional sublicense terms. [21]	Potentially simpler license formation; this is a vehicle **after** startup direction becomes credible, not a reason to create one.	Qualifying startup/ IP conditions apply; contact OTM before assuming eligibility.	OTM New Next: licen → compar developm [22]
Skandalaris Venture Development	Investigator wants low-commitment help thinking through an idea, business model, financial model, pitch or next entrepreneurial step.	30-minute advising; brainstorming, business plans, financial models, pitching and next-step guidance. [23]	Excellent “is entrepreneurship even sensible?” entry point. **No incorporation or mature startup is required.**	WashU students, faculty, staff and alumni; ventures may be at any stage. [23]	`sc@wust` 314-935-9 customer mentoring formation [Official](#) [24

Resource	Useful when	What you get	Investigator benefit / what you do *not* need to do	Eligibility and status	Contact / l step / offic
Skandalaris In-Residence / IdeaBounce	Investigator wants founder/ industry feedback, networking or a low-stakes venue for testing how an idea is communicated.	Experienced entrepreneur/ industry perspectives; IdeaBounce provides pitching, feedback and networking opportunities. [25]	Useful before committing to a venture. **You do not need a finished company or investor deck.**	Skandalaris services broadly include WashU faculty/staff/ students/alumni; individual event/ program requirements vary.	`sc@wust` venture ac collaborat discovery. [26]
Skandalaris Venture Competition — SVC	Mainly when an eligible student/ recent-alumni venture **does not rely on university IP**.	Competition awards; current Fall 2026 materials describe an awards pool of up to $25,000, subject to award limits per startup. [4]	Can provide venture validation and money, **but it should normally be suppressed for a faculty WashU-IP invention**.	Critical trap: qualifying WashU student/recent alum and ownership rules apply; **WashU IP is not permitted, nor is a license to IP from WashU or another university**. [4]	Skandalar [4]
Neurotech Hub	A neuroscientist has an experimental/ technical problem, concept or prototype that needs engineering and technical development.	On-demand technical services and development of new technical paradigms/tools for neuroscience. [27]	Directly converts technical innovation into research capability, preliminary data, prototypes and potentially protectable inventions. **You do not need a commercial plan before engaging.**	Neuroscience-oriented WashU resource; precise project prioritization and service terms should be stored as **unspecified/ locally managed** where not publicly stated.	Official / A

Resource	Useful when	What you get	Investigator benefit / what you do *not* need to do	Eligibility and status	Contact / l step / offic
Hope Center for Neurological Disorders	Work addresses neurological disease and needs collaborative pilot funding, specialized neuroscience infrastructure or translational community.	Translational neuroscience community and pilot opportunities. Current pilot eligibility requires the project PI to be a Hope Center faculty member; cycle-specific requirements change. 28	Pilot data, collaborators and neuroscience-specific infrastructure can strengthen papers and external grant applications. **Commercialization is not required.**	Hope Center faculty membership required for PI of current pilot program; collaborator membership rules are less restrictive. 29	[Official](#) / [P](#) 29
ICTS Research Forum	Investigator has a translational concept/grant but needs study design, milestones, statistical input, expert critique, collaborators or grant review.	Multidisciplinary project-development or grant-review roundtables covering study design, aims, methods, statistics, milestones, stakeholder engagement and dissemination. Applications are year-round. 30	Particularly valuable for turning "promising invention" into rigorous translational evidence and competitive grants. **No commercialization plan or company is required.**	Available to ICTS members across career stages/ partner affiliations. 30	ICTS navig `icts@wu` Next: stre grant/proj extramura clinical stu 30

Resource	Useful when	What you get	Investigator benefit / what you do *not* need to do	Eligibility and status	Contact / [illegible] step / offic[illegible]
ICTS CTRFP / Just-In-Time funding	Translational pilot evidence or targeted core-services data are the immediate bottleneck.	CTRFP current categories provide up to $50,000 direct costs for one-year clinical/ translational or community-engaged projects and up to $25,000 for biostatistics/ epidemiology/ research-design projects. JIT provides rapid core-service support for preliminary data or certain QA/QI work. [31]	Generates data that can drive grants, papers and translation. **Does not require startup formation or a licensing objective.**	CTRFP PI must be an ICTS member. 2026 LOI deadline has passed; invited full applications are due September 14, 2026. JIT has separate rolling processes and limits. [32]	`icts@wu` `JIT@wus` CTRFP / JI
Needleman Program for Innovation & Commercialization — NPIC	A promising WashU **therapeutic candidate** needs drug-development work beyond normal discovery science to approach an IND/ clinical testing.	Funding plus drug-discovery/ development expertise and business mentoring; NPIC's stated objective is to move promising therapeutic candidates toward FDA investigational-new-drug status. [33]	Provides capabilities most academic labs are not organized to execute and can preserve the PI's focus on science. **A startup is not required.**	During open windows, **PIs from any WashU school or department** are invited to apply. Public page currently says applications are closed and a future RFP is planned. [34]	`npic@wu` MSC 1182 Euclid Ave Applicatio [35]

Resource	Useful when	What you get	Investigator benefit / what you do *not* need to do	Eligibility and status	Contact / l step / offic
VeritaScience — WashU + Deerfield Management	Therapeutic/ diagnostic discovery needs a milestone-driven drug-development plan, specialized industry capabilities and substantial development capital.	Deerfield committed up to $130 million over ten years across the collaboration; accepted drug-discovery projects receive development plans aimed toward IND readiness and may receive further funding/support, including possible company formation. 36	Gives investigators access to industry drug-development expertise and capital **without requiring a pre-existing startup**.	WashU investigator proposals; disease indication may vary. Current standing submission dates and detailed eligibility are **unspecified publicly** in the source reviewed.	Routing is WashU/De scientific r by OTM ar business c Older Was informatio contact: O (`doscar@` verify befo Official Wa announce
Bristol Myers Squibb–WashU neuroscience collaboration	A neuroscience therapeutic program or trainee would benefit from direct pharmaceutical-development engagement.	Multiyear collaboration funding up to three translational neuroscience research programs per year and up to three visiting fellows per year, with work alongside BMS scientists. 38	Especially attractive for **collaboration, translational expertise, trainee development and drug-development exposure** without startup formation.	Priority areas include neurological, neuromuscular, neuroinflammatory and psychiatric conditions. The first announced EOI deadline was September 1, 2026, which has passed as of this report; future rounds should be monitored. 38	Mark Van Director, S External P Outreach, `markv@w` Official 38

Resource	Useful when	What you get	Investigator benefit / what you do *not* need to do	Eligibility and status	Contact / next step / offic
NEURO360 / regional neuroscience innovation network	The opportunity needs regional neuroscience-industry connections, ecosystem visibility or future cluster-scale initiatives rather than a single institutional service.	A WashU-led regional neuroscience innovation effort originally supported through an NSF Engines Development Award and involving regional organizations including BioSTL. [39]	Potential network layer connecting academic neuroscience to regional company-building and workforce/ economic-development resources.	A standing individual-investigator application route is **not publicly specified**; model this as an ecosystem/ network node rather than guaranteed funding.	Route thro WashU ne innovation regional e pages; pro should be reverified.

A useful architectural distinction is visible here: **OTM, Neurotech Hub, ICTS, Hope Center and Needleman can all be relevant before a company exists**, whereas startup-specific capital and competitions should occur later. The app should not visually place all "innovation resources" at the same stage. [40]

Regional, federal, investor and partner resources

Resource	Useful when	What you get	Investigator benefit / what you do *not* need to do	Eligibility / trap	Contact / next step / o
BioSTL / BioGenerator Ventures	A bioscience opportunity is becoming a company, or founders need investment, experienced operators, laboratory space, industry/investor connections or venture creation support.	BioGenerator provides early-stage capital, expert guidance, lab space and hands-on company support in human health and agriculture. [41]	Strong regional bridge from university invention to investable company and external talent. First conversation can precede a mature fundraising round.	Focus on high-growth science-based companies; exact investment criteria/terms are deal-specific and **unspecified** as a universal program rule.	BioGenerator / BioSTL

Resource	Useful when	What you get	Investigator benefit / what you do *not* need to do	Eligibility / trap	Contact / next step / o
BioGenerator Startup Connect	Startup is sufficiently mature to benefit from curated investor/ ecosystem meetings.	Invite-only presentations, investor meetings and networking among human-health/agriculture startups, investors, academics, government and corporate partners. Current event: Sept. 9–10, 2026. [43]	Investor exposure without relying only on cold outreach.	Invite-only; not an early idea-development program.	`aj@biogeneratorve` Official [43]
Cortex SQ1 Ignite / Bootcamp	Someone wants structured entrepreneurship/ customer/ business-model education before or during very early venture formation.	Ignite is a four-week concept-stage program using business-model validation, mentors and ecosystem connections; Bootcamp is a more intensive ten-week/50-hour program. [44]	Low-cost way to test entrepreneurial assumptions. **You do not need an investor-ready company to enter Ignite.**	Ignite prerequisites are light; current listed fee is $50 with need-based scholarships. Cohort dates vary. [45]	`info@cortexstl.or` Bootcamp, venture cr regional accelerators.

Resource	Useful when	What you get	Investigator benefit / what you do *not* need to do	Eligibility / trap	Contact / next step / o
Arch Grants Startup Competition	A genuine startup can commit to building in St. Louis and wants non-dilutive startup capital and ecosystem access.	$75,000 equity-free; an additional $25,000 for qualifying relocations; eligibility for follow-on Growth Grants up to $100,000; fundraising and network support. [5]	Capital without giving Arch Grants equity.	Company headquarters in St. Louis ≥1 year; residency/ team requirements; at least one founder currently must work on company as primary/full-time role. **2026 applications are closed.** [5]	`competition@archg` Official [46]
Missouri Technology Corporation IDEA Fund	A Missouri technology startup is raising an institutional pre-seed/seed/ Series A round and can attract matching private capital.	Current tracks include TechLaunch, up to $250,000 for companies raising < $1M; Seed Capital, up to $1M for $1–5M raises; larger venture track also exists. MTC investments require private matching capital. [47]	Can leverage an external financing round with state-backed investment.	**This is equity investment, not an academic grant.** Missouri location/ growth requirements and matching co-investment apply. The earlier proof-of-concept pilot is currently paused. [48]	MTC IDEA Fund team.

Resource	Useful when	What you get	Investigator benefit / what you do *not* need to do	Eligibility / trap	Contact / next step / o
Missouri SBDC FAST / SBIR-STTR assistance	Founder is considering federal SBIR/STTR and needs proposal strategy, training or submission support.	Missouri SBDC's FAST program provides resources, expertise and assistance navigating SBIR/STTR proposal submission. [50]	Particularly useful for an academic founder who understands the science but not the federal small-business process. **No venture-capital fundraising is required to seek advising.**	Targeted to small businesses / prospective SBIR-STTR applicants; current grants/services vary by FAST cycle.	Official [50]
Cultivation Capital — Life Sciences & Health Tech	Startup has a credible financing proposition in therapeutics, diagnostics, research tools/reagents, devices or health technology.	St. Louis-based venture capital; current site describes initial checks roughly \$100,000–\$3.5 million and investing from seed through Series B. [51]	Regional capital plus investor perspective and network.	Requires an investable company/opportunity; no standardized investigator eligibility. **Not a grant.**	Official [52]
RiverVest Venture Partners	Biopharma or medical-device company needs sophisticated life-science company formation/venture financing.	St. Louis-headquartered life-science VC that funds and founds biopharma and device companies and can lead financing syndicates. [53]	Useful when the question has progressed from "is there a product?" to "is this a venture-scale company?"	Company/investment diligence required; terms opportunity-specific.	`info@rivervest.c` 314-726-6700. Official

Resource	Useful when	What you get	Investigator benefit / what you do *not* need to do	Eligibility / trap	Contact / next step / o
Osage University Partners — OUP	University-originated science has venture-scale potential and the company needs investors familiar with academic IP/ spinouts.	VC focused on science-driven startups from research ecosystems; current sectors include therapeutics, medtech, diagnostics and research tools; current site states \$1M–\$20M investment size across stages. [55]	Investor familiar with university technology-transfer/company-formation issues.	Investment opportunity required; no grant or general faculty assistance program.	Official [55]
NIH SBIR/ STTR	A product-oriented biomedical R&D project should move into a U.S. small business while preserving substantial non-dilutive research funding.	Non-dilutive federal R&D funding; NIH currently accepts applications through parent and specific NOFOs three times per year. The programs were reauthorized in April 2026. [56]	Can fund scientists, engineers, prototypes, preclinical work and commercialization-oriented R&D while retaining company equity.	**Academic lab alone is not an eligible applicant.** Applicant must satisfy U.S. small-business criteria; STTR requires formal research-institution participation. [57]	NIH SEED. Official fun opportunities [58]

Resource	Useful when	What you get	Investigator benefit / what you do *not* need to do	Eligibility / trap	Contact / next step / o
I-Corps at NIH	An NIH-funded Phase I small business needs intensive customer discovery and commercialization learning.	Structured commercialization/ customer-discovery program; NIH SEED describes a three-person team model and program support. 59	Excellent after technical feasibility when product/customer assumptions are still uncertain.	Generally requires an eligible recent/active NIH/CDC/ FDA/ACL Phase I SBIR/ STTR award and no Phase II award yet; **not an entry program for an unfunded academic idea**. 59	Official 59
NCATS Small Business Programs	Technology addresses a translational-science bottleneck, platform or broadly enabling biomedical need and a company is being considered.	SBIR/STTR funding/program guidance aligned with translational science; NCATS encourages prospective applicants to discuss program fit. 60	Useful for platforms/tools that may not fit a single disease-oriented institute cleanly.	NIH small-business eligibility applies to SBIR/STTR.	`NCATS-SBIRSTTR@ma` Official 61

Resource	Useful when	What you get	Investigator benefit / what you do *not* need to do	Eligibility / trap	Contact / next step / o
NINDS Translational Devices + Small Business Program	Device/ neurotechnology addresses a nervous-system disorder and needs milestone-driven translation, optimization, regulatory preparation or first-in-human work.	NINDS Translational Devices supports development, optimization, translation and first-in-human testing of therapeutic/ diagnostic devices; NINDS also has dedicated small-business programs. 62	Exceptionally high-value neuroscience-specific route; can finance evidence that academic R01-style projects often do not emphasize.	Eligibility depends on specific NOFO; some routes are academic, others small-business-only. **Navigator must inspect the actual current NOFO rather than infer eligibility from the program family.**	Translational Devices / Business 62
NIA Small Business — Alzheimer's/ ADRD and aging	An Alzheimer's, ADRD or aging-related diagnostic, tool, therapeutic or service has a plausible small-business path.	NIA maintains a dedicated SBIR/ STTR program and reports more than $140M/year in small-business support across aging and AD/ ADRD areas. 63	Neuroscience-specific non-dilutive capital for one of WashU's major strengths.	Small-business program requirements apply; specific NOFO deadlines and areas should be queried live.	Official 63
NSF I-Corps	Deep-tech/ scientific invention needs systematic customer discovery and may fit NSF's technology-commercialization ecosystem better than NIH.	National I-Corps teams combine technical, entrepreneurial and industry perspectives around customer discovery. 64	Useful for instrumentation, engineering, computation and research tools where clinical-disease programs are a poor fit.	Current team/award eligibility depends on NSF route; do not assume every WashU invention qualifies.	Official 64

The regional financing landscape forms a useful **capital ladder** rather than a single pool: Gap/ICTS/Hope funding can create evidence while the asset remains primarily academic; BioGenerator can participate in company creation and early capital; Arch Grants adds equity-free company funding but substantial founder/location obligations; MTC co-invests alongside private capital; and Cultivation, RiverVest and OUP become more relevant as a venture-quality financing case emerges. [65]

Navigator model: states, destinations and transitions

The navigator should maintain two separate concepts:

Current state: "What do you have now?"

Destination: "What would success look like to you?"

This is intentionally different from WashU's institutional process map. It is an investigator-centered synthesis based on the services and readiness gates found across OTM, ICTS, Needleman, Skandalaris and regional programs. [66]

The recommended ten states are:

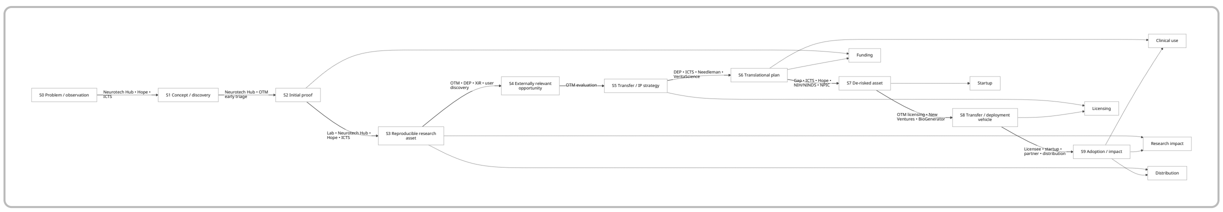
ID	Inventor state	Evidence that the investigator is here
S0	**Problem / observation**	Unmet scientific, technical or clinical need; no defined solution yet.
S1	**Concept / discovery**	Hypothesis, mechanism, algorithm, target, design or new use exists.
S2	**Initial proof of principle**	First experiment, simulation or benchtop prototype suggests feasibility.
S3	**Reproducible research asset**	Method/device/software/compound/assay works repeatedly under defined conditions.
S4	**Externally relevant opportunity**	A user, clinician, company or external expert can articulate why it matters outside the originating lab.
S5	**Transfer/IP strategy defined**	OTM has evaluated the opportunity; protection, licensing, distribution or other transfer approach is understood.
S6	**Translational plan defined**	Team knows which specific technical, regulatory, clinical, usability, manufacturing or market risks must be resolved.
S7	**De-risked translational asset**	Critical external-facing milestone(s) have been achieved with evidence acceptable beyond the originating lab.
S8	**Transfer/deployment vehicle ready**	Licensee, distribution mechanism, industry partnership or startup/company structure is actionable.
S9	**Adoption / clinical / market impact**	Real external users, researchers, patients, licensees or customers receive sustained value.

The six selectable destination outcomes are:

1. **Clinical use:** “I want this eventually used in patient care.”
2. **Licensing:** “I want another organization to develop and deploy it.”
3. **Startup:** “I want to build a company around this.”
4. **Research impact:** “I want this to strengthen science—mine and others'.”
5. **Funding:** “I want resources to continue the research/development.”
6. **Distribution/adoption:** “I want researchers or other users to actually get and use it.”

Funding is deliberately retained as a destination even though it is technically an intermediate state because it is often the **investigator's immediate objective**; the navigator can subsequently ask what the funding is intended to accomplish.

The resource annotations below are based on current program purposes: OTM handles invention/IP/licensing; DEP and XiR provide external expertise; the Gap Fund handles non-drug translational de-risking; Needleman and VeritaScience address therapeutic development; ICTS supports translational design/funding; and Skandalaris/BioGenerator support venture development. 67



The graph should permit **skipping states and looping backward**. A highly mature scientific asset may enter at S3 or S4; an external expert may reveal that an apparent S7 asset has not actually validated the relevant user need, sending it back to S4. That is normal translational learning, not failure.

The most useful edges for an app implementation are:

From → to	Question the navigator asks	Evidence needed to cross	Recommended resource annotations
S0 → S1	“Can you state the problem and proposed solution separately?”	Defined need/problem and candidate approach.	Neurotech Hub for technical problems; ICTS/Hope for clinical/translational framing. 68
S1 → S2	“What is the cheapest convincing test of the core principle?”	First decisive feasibility experiment/prototype.	Neurotech Hub; laboratory; ICTS JIT where eligible. 69
S2 → S3	“Does it work reliably enough that somebody other than the inventor can evaluate it?”	Repeatability, controls, defined protocol/performance.	Department/lab; Hope pilots; ICTS; Neurotech Hub. 70

From → to	Question the navigator asks	Evidence needed to cross	Recommended resource annotations
S3 → S4	"Who outside your lab cares, and what do they actually need?"	External user/clinical/ industry feedback.	DEP, XiR, Skandalaris Venture Development, ICTS stakeholder support. [71]
S3/S4 → S5	"Should we protect, license, distribute, partner, open-release —or combine these?"	OTM evaluation and transfer strategy.	OTM core. [10]
S4/S5 → S6	"What three uncertainties prevent an external party from saying yes?"	Prioritized risk list and milestone plan.	DEP; ICTS Research Forum; Needleman for drugs; VeritaScience for drug/ diagnostic projects; NINDS for neural devices. [72]
S6 → S7 non-drug	"What experiment/ prototype removes the largest transfer risk?"	Milestone-linked data.	Gap Fund, ICTS, Hope, NIH/ NINDS translational grants. [73]
S6 → S7 therapeutic	"What is required to move toward a development candidate/IND?"	Target/product profile, efficacy/safety/ developability and milestone package appropriate to modality.	Needleman, VeritaScience, NINDS/NIH as appropriate; BMS collaboration where aligned. [74]
S7 → S8 license	"Is there an organization that can take this forward?"	Transfer package, diligence materials, interested counterparty.	OTM licensing + industry/ network connections. [75]
S7 → S8 startup	"Does this require a new company, and who will run it?"	Team, IP/license path, customer evidence, financing plan.	OTM New Ventures/EIR, Skandalaris, BioGenerator, Cortex. [76]
S8 → S9 startup financing	"What capital matches the next company milestone?"	Company, budget/use of proceeds and fundable milestones.	NIH SBIR/STTR, BioGenerator, Arch Grants, MTC, Cultivation, RiverVest, OUP. [77]
S3/S5 → distribution	"Is the objective broad scientific use rather than venture formation?"	Stable tool/software/ reagent, documentation/ support and transfer terms.	OTM transfer guidance + academic distribution strategy; commercial manufacturer/licensee if scale is required. [10]

For implementation, each state should also track orthogonal fields rather than hide them in one "TRL" score:

```
technical_readiness
scientific_validation
ip_status
external_need_validation
regulatory_status
clinical_evidence
manufacturing_readiness
team_readiness
funding_readiness
transfer_vehicle
```

That matters because a device can have excellent scientific evidence but no manufacturable design; software can have hundreds of academic users but an unresolved licensing situation; and a patented therapeutic target can still be years from a development candidate.

Investigator motivations and academic returns

The navigator should begin with a question closer to **“What would make spending time on this worthwhile to you?”** than “Do you want to commercialize this?”

The table below is an analytical model, not a measured ranking. **H/M/L describe likely alignment**, and outcomes depend on the technology and investigator. The underlying program landscape demonstrates that translation can generate research funding, external expertise, trainee opportunities, dissemination and industry collaboration independently of startup creation. [78]

Path	Publications / scientific outputs	Grants / lab support	Trainee opportunities	Collaboration	Reach / patient impact	Financial/ equity upside	Faculty time burden
Continue as academic research + translational grants	**H**	**H**	**H**	M–H	M	L	M
Broad academic/ open distribution	**H**	M	M	**H**	H for research tools	L	M–H if lab must support users
License to established company	M	M	M	**H**	**H** if licensee executes	M, uncertain	**L–M**

Path	Publications / scientific outputs	Grants / lab support	Trainee opportunities	Collaboration	Reach / patient impact	Financial/ equity upside	Faculty time burden
Structured industry collaboration	M–H	**H** through project support	**H**	**H**	H	L–M	M
Startup with external operator/CEO	M	M–H	H	H	**H** if successful	**H potential, high uncertainty**	M–H
Faculty-led startup	L–M unless scientifically integrated	M–H	M–H	H	**H potential**	**H potential, high uncertainty**	**Very high**
Therapeutic accelerator/ partner path	M	H	H	**H**	**H**	Variable	M
Research-tool commercial manufacturer/ licensee	H	M	M	H	**H** across scientific community	M	**L–M**

This suggests several motivation-first routes.

“I want papers and new science.” The highest-value path is usually to ask whether innovation work creates a new method, dataset, validation study, translational question or external collaboration. Neurotech Hub, Hope Center and ICTS are particularly compatible with this objective because their core mission is research/translation rather than company formation. [79]

“I need grants and people.” The navigator should emphasize milestones that double as preliminary data: ICTS CTRFP/JIT, Hope pilots, NINDS translational programs and, for non-drug commercialization gaps, the WashU Gap Fund. SBIR/STTR becomes attractive only after a company structure is justified. [80]

“I want my trainees to gain opportunities.” Industry collaborations deserve unusually high visibility. WashU's 2026 BMS collaboration explicitly combines translational neuroscience projects with visiting-fellow placements at BMS, making industrial exposure itself an academic return. [38]

“I want other scientists to use this.” A startup is only one option. Depending on what scaling requires, the correct vehicle could be academic distribution, a manufacturer, software distribution, an OTM-mediated license, or a specialized research-tool company. The navigator should ask who will perform manufacturing, documentation, support, quality control and distribution before recommending a vehicle.

“I want this to reach patients.” Clinical impact should be treated as a destination and then planned backward through evidence, regulatory and deployment requirements. Needleman, VeritaScience, BMS, NINDS Translational Devices and ICTS occupy different portions of this route. [81]

“I want financial upside.” Licensing income or startup equity can be legitimate motivations, but neither is guaranteed. The navigator should not equate equity ownership with value creation. The WashU Quick Start License illustrates that startup licensing itself can have standardized economic terms, while external venture investors necessarily impose a different capital/ownership relationship. [82]

A particularly useful result page could therefore report **expected academic returns as well as recommended programs**:

> **Path: Validate → OTM/DEP → Gap Fund → license to established device company**
> Likely academic returns: new validation data, trainee project, possible methods paper, industry collaborators, broad product distribution, possible inventor licensing return.
> Faculty commitment: moderate during validation, potentially much lower than founder-led startup.
> Company formation: **not required**.

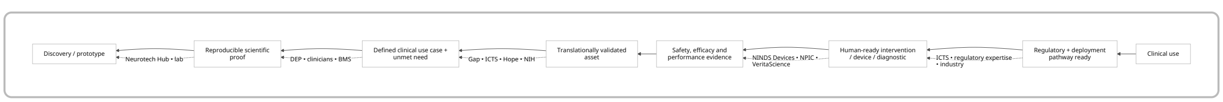
This is the central behavioral advantage of the navigator: it can make commercialization work feel like an extension of academic strategy rather than an unrelated administrative burden.

Backward-planning templates

The backward-planning mode should start from the desired endpoint and ask which required milestone is currently missing. These are **generic evidence ladders**, not claims that every technology must complete every step; modality-specific regulatory, clinical and IP requirements should be supplied by OTM, ICTS, FDA-facing experts and relevant programs.

Clinical use

Needleman targets therapeutic candidates approaching IND readiness, VeritaScience provides drug-development planning/expertise, NINDS Translational Devices explicitly supports device translation through first-in-human work, and ICTS provides clinical/translational research infrastructure. [83]



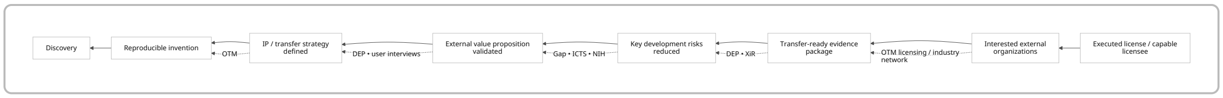
Checklist:

- Define **who the patient/user is and the clinical decision/intervention being changed**.
- Establish reproducible technical/biological performance.
- Identify the largest remaining safety, efficacy, usability, regulatory and implementation uncertainties.
- Separate **therapeutic** routing (Needleman/VeritaScience) from **device/neurotechnology** routing (NINDS Translational Devices/Gap/ICTS). [84]

- Decide who ultimately manufactures, sponsors, regulates, deploys and supports the product: licensee, strategic partner or startup.
- Make the immediate next experiment correspond to one of those downstream uncertainties—not merely another academically interesting experiment.

Licensing

OTM is the central WashU mechanism for invention evaluation and licensing, with DEP providing industry-facing de-risking feedback and the Gap Fund supporting non-drug translational work. [85]



Checklist:

- Ask **which existing companies already possess manufacturing, regulatory, sales or distribution capability**.
- Establish what data those potential licensees would need before diligence.
- Use OTM/DEP feedback to distinguish scientific curiosity from a transferrable asset. [14]
- Fund only the de-risking milestones that materially improve transferability.
- Build a concise package: problem, differentiation, evidence, IP/transfer status, remaining risks and intended use.
- Do **not** form a startup solely because an invention exists; licensing is explicitly a separate route through OTM.

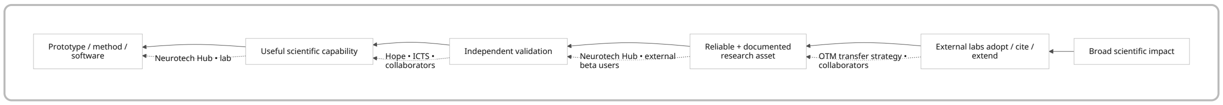
Startup

OTM New Ventures/EIR, Skandalaris, BioGenerator and Cortex all provide different startup-building functions, while NIH SBIR/STTR, Arch Grants, MTC and regional VCs become relevant at different financing stages. [86]

Checklist:

- Answer **why a new company is necessary** rather than assuming it.
- Identify who will run the company; faculty inventor and operating CEO need not be the same person.
- Validate a customer/use case before optimizing a pitch deck.
- Clarify university IP/license route with OTM. EIR eligibility itself assumes foundational WashU patent rights for the startup. [87]
- Match capital to company stage: SBIR/STTR or BioGenerator early; Arch Grants when founder/location requirements fit; MTC when matching private capital exists; institutional VC when the financing case warrants it. [88]
- Suppress Skandalaris SVC for a WashU-IP startup because the current competition explicitly prohibits that IP/licensing structure. [4]

Research impact

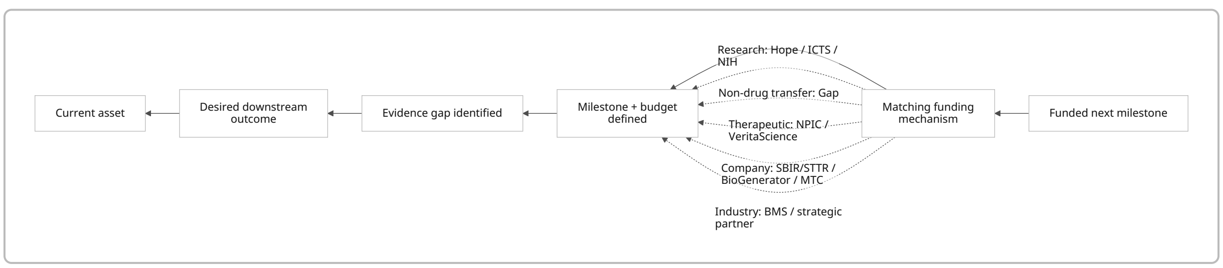


Checklist:

- Define impact in measurable academic terms: users, citations, replicated findings, collaborations, datasets, follow-on grants or enabled experiments.
- Determine whether support/manufacturing demands make direct laboratory distribution unsustainable.
- Validate with at least one independent lab/user before optimizing for scale.
- Decide deliberately among open/academic release, OTM-mediated licensing and commercial manufacturing/distribution.
- Make documentation, reproducibility and usability part of the scientific deliverable rather than post-hoc commercialization work.
- Capture resulting papers, methods, collaborations and grant leverage as formal “returns” in the navigator.

Funding

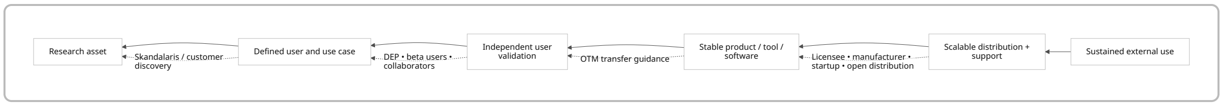
WashU investigators have several fundamentally different funding categories: conventional/translational academic support through ICTS/Hope, commercialization de-risking through Gap, therapeutic development through Needleman/VeritaScience, industry-sponsored routes such as BMS, and company-only routes such as SBIR/STTR and MTC. [89]



Checklist:

- Never begin with “Where can I get money?” Begin with **“What evidence will the money buy?”**
- Specify the milestone, cost, duration and downstream decision enabled.
- If the next milestone primarily advances science: ICTS/Hope/NIH.
- If it resolves commercial uncertainty in a non-drug WashU technology: Gap Fund. [16]
- If it develops a therapeutic toward IND: Needleman/VeritaScience. [90]
- If the work should sit inside a company: NIH SBIR/STTR; Missouri SBDC can assist with the application process. [91]
- Treat grant award as an **intermediate success**, then return the user to the destination graph.

Distribution / adoption



Checklist:

- Define the user and how they obtain the asset.
- Determine whether the laboratory can realistically handle fabrication, hosting, documentation, updates, support and quality control.
- Test the tool with independent users.
- Select the lightest-weight scalable transfer mechanism.
- Engage OTM when university IP, licensing or commercialization obligations may be implicated. 10
- Optimize for **actual use**, not merely disclosure, patent issuance, incorporation or website publication.

Ecosystem gaps, routing hazards and MVP priorities

From the investigator's perspective, the largest gap is not a missing accelerator. It is the absence of a **cross-program decision layer**. WashU's Innovation site catalogs a rich ecosystem and OTM itself provides multiple expert, funding and startup programs, but the investigator must still translate between scientific state, personal motivation, modality, eligibility and institutional terminology. This conclusion is an inference from the organization of the official resource/process pages rather than a claim made by WashU itself. 92

The most important app opportunities are these:

Motivation is currently under-modeled. The navigator should ask about papers, grants, trainees, scientific reach, patient impact, faculty time, control and financial upside before asking “startup or license?” This creates paths for inventors who are innovation-positive but entrepreneurship-negative.

The ecosystem contains overlapping “expert help” with different purposes. DEP, XiR, EIR, Skandalaris Venture Development/In-Residence, ICTS Research Forum and Cortex SQ1 can all sound like “mentoring,” but they solve different problems: commercial-domain diligence, expert access, founder coaching, general venture development, translational scientific design and business-model education, respectively. 93 The app should route on the **question needing an answer**, not the generic word “mentor.”

Modality is a critical early gate. A therapeutic candidate can route toward Needleman and VeritaScience; a non-drug technology can be appropriate for Gap; a neural device may fit NINDS Translational Devices; a research tool or software platform may be better served by distribution/licensing or a research-tool company. 94 A single generic “translational funding” card would obscure this.

Programs contain significant eligibility traps. The strongest example is Skandalaris SVC's explicit exclusion of WashU/university IP. Arch Grants requires serious founder and St. Louis commitments. MTC is matching investment rather than a grant. NIH SBIR/STTR requires a small business. I-Corps at NIH is downstream of a qualifying Phase I award rather than an early academic customer-discovery program. ICTS CTRFP requires membership. 95 The app should display these constraints **before** showing enthusiastic program copy.

Funding timelines are transient data. The navigator should not hard-code calls as evergreen resources. NPIC currently says applications are closed; Arch Grants 2026 is closed; BMS's first EOI date has passed; MTC already exposes future 2027 cycles; ICTS has stage-specific 2026 deadlines. [96] Every opportunity record should contain `status`, `next_deadline`, `last_verified`, `source_url`, and preferably a distinction between **evergreen service** and **competitive call**.

There is no natural "I don't want a company" branch in most entrepreneurship interfaces. The navigator should explicitly offer "get it used without becoming a founder," leading toward licensing, industry partnership, external manufacturing or distribution.

Academic return should be made visible. A Gap-funded validation study, BMS trainee placement, ICTS pilot, external beta test or industry collaboration may directly produce data, grant leverage, collaborations and trainee opportunities even if no startup emerges. [97] These should be reported as successful innovation outcomes.

Evidence-based readiness should replace "stage" labels alone. "Early stage" means radically different things for a molecule, implantable device, analysis package and research instrument. The app should ask modality-specific evidence questions and then render the state graph.

Handoff ownership is unclear to investigators. Each recommendation should therefore include a single actionable sentence: "Contact X and send Y." For example, "Email OTM with your existing disclosure number and ask whether DEP is appropriate," rather than merely linking to DEP.

Dynamic partnerships need a different schema from permanent programs. VeritaScience is a long-term structured relationship, whereas BMS currently has announced annual project/fellow slots with specific calls. [98] The navigator should represent partner opportunities as dated overlays on the permanent path graph.

A resource card needs a negative field. `not_for` is nearly as important as `useful_when`. Examples: `Gap Fund: not drug projects`; `NPIC: not generic non-therapeutic devices`; `SVC: not WashU IP`; `NIH SBIR: not an academic lab acting alone`; `MTC: not grant funding`. [99]

A practical app object might therefore be:

```
{
  "resource_name": "Washington University Gap Fund",
  "resource_type": "translational_funding",
  "useful_when": ["non-drug", "WashU technology", "specific de-risking
milestone"],
  "not_for": ["drug development", "general unfocused research support"],
  "company_required": false,
  "disclosure_or_ip_gate": "OTM-routed",
  "investigator_returns": [
    "funded development work",
    "validation data",
    "technology value",
```

```
    "possible grant/publication leverage"
  ],
  "next_state": ["de-risked translational asset"],
  "status": "evergreen_program_verify_current_call",
  "last_verified": "2026-09-04",
  "source_url": "https://otm.wustl.edu/disclose-inventions/gap-fund/"
}
```


The recommended **first twelve MVP cards**, in order of routing value, are:

Priority	MVP card	Why it belongs in v1	Primary state transition
Core	**OTM / department tech-transfer contact**	Nearly every protect/transfer/license path needs it; prevents premature patent/startup assumptions. [100]	S3–S5
Core	**Neurotech Hub**	Neuroscience-specific “bring me a problem” front door; creates prototypes/data before commercialization is even defined. [27]	S0–S3
Core	**Domain Expert Program**	Answers “does the outside world care and what evidence will matter?” [14]	S3–S6
Core	**Gap Fund**	Direct mechanism for de-risking non-drug WashU inventions; does not require a company. [16]	S6–S7
Core	**Needleman NPIC**	Essential modality-specific branch for therapeutics; any WashU school/department PI may apply during open windows. [34]	S5–S7
Core	**ICTS Research Forum + CTRFP/JIT**	Bridges innovation and rigorous translational/ grant development, with both expertise and funding. [101]	S1–S7
Core	**Hope Center**	Neuroscience disease-specific collaborators, pilot funding and translational community. [28]	S1–S4
Core	**XiR**	External expertise without immediately turning the project into a founder exercise. [17]	S4–S6
Core	**OTM New Ventures / EIR**	Right startup-specific WashU pathway once the company hypothesis is real. [19]	S7–S8
Core	**Skandalaris Venture Development**	Very low-friction entrepreneurial exploration for faculty before startup commitment. [23]	S4–S8

Priority	MVP card	Why it belongs in v1	Primary state transition
Core regional	**BioGenerator Ventures**	Best regional bridge into life-science company formation, capital, talent and lab infrastructure. [102]	S7–S9
Core federal	**NIH/NINDS + Missouri SBIR/STTR support**	Converts suitable inventions into substantial non-dilutive translational/company R&D and provides local application support. [103]	S6–S9

Second-wave cards should include VeritaScience, the BMS neuroscience collaboration, Quick Start License, Cortex SQ1, Arch Grants, MTC, NIA AD/ADRD small-business funding, Cultivation, RiverVest, OUP, NIH I-Corps and SVC as a mostly-negative eligibility rule. Their value is high but they are more conditional on modality, timing or company stage. [104]

The resulting v1 interaction can be remarkably small:

```
WHAT DO YOU HAVE?
  observation / data / target / software / prototype /
  device / therapeutic / research tool / existing disclosure

            ↓

WHAT WOULD SUCCESS LOOK LIKE?
  clinical use / license / startup /
  research impact / funding / distribution / unsure

            ↓

WHAT MATTERS TO YOU?
  papers / grants / trainees / collaborators /
  reach / patients / financial upside / low time burden

            ↓

READINESS + ELIGIBILITY QUESTIONS

            ↓

YOUR NEXT 1–3 MILESTONES
  each with:
  why this matters
  evidence required
  academic return
  recommended resource
```

```
what you do NOT need to do
eligibility trap
named contact
```

That is enough structure to make the larger ecosystem useful without attempting to capture every WashU program on day one.

Annotated primary-source bibliography

The sources below should form the **seed corpus** for the navigator's retrieval layer. They are prioritized by authority, routing importance and likelihood of answering user-facing eligibility questions. Program records should retain the source URL and a `last_verified` date so changing cycles do not silently become stale.

WashU Innovation — home, ecosystem and process. The best high-level source for WashU's institutional innovation framework and ecosystem taxonomy. Particularly useful as a discovery index, but less useful for investigator-specific eligibility. FY26 dashboard information also provides current institutional context. [105]
Official: https://innovation.washu.edu/
Process: https://innovation.washu.edu/our-process/
Ecosystem: https://innovation.washu.edu/our-ecosystem/

Office of Technology Management — Licensing Process. Primary source for invention disclosure, OTM evaluation and the institutional path to licensing; should be authoritative for disclosure-related routing. [10]
Official: https://otm.wustl.edu/disclose-inventions/licensing-process/

OTM — department-specific technology-transfer contacts. Essential for converting an abstract recommendation into a named institutional handoff; neuroscience-related departments are included in the lookup. [11]
Official: https://otm.wustl.edu/disclose-inventions/otm-contact-by-washu-department/

OTM — Domain Expert Program. Primary source for industry/investor expert evaluation, commercial-potential feedback and de-risking recommendations. [13]
Official: https://otm.wustl.edu/items/domain-expert-program-dep/

OTM — Washington University Gap Fund. Primary source for non-drug translational funding and current funding mechanics; a critical modality/eligibility card. [15]
Official: https://otm.wustl.edu/disclose-inventions/gap-fund/

OTM — Experts-in-Residence and Entrepreneur-in-Residence/New Ventures. Needed to distinguish expert/domain advice from startup-founder coaching; EIR also carries important WashU-IP/startup eligibility logic. [106]
XiR: https://otm.wustl.edu/items/experts-in-residence/
EIR: https://otm.wustl.edu/items/entrepreneur-in-residence/
New Ventures: https://otm.wustl.edu/disclose-inventions/new-ventures/

OTM — Quick Start License. Primary source when a WashU-IP startup reaches licensing; useful because it publishes unusually concrete terms and therefore helps distinguish company formation from vague

“commercialization.” [21]
Official: https://otm.wustl.edu/disclose-inventions/quick-start-license/

Skandalaris Center — Programs and Venture Development. Primary entrepreneurship resource. Venture Development is especially valuable in an inventor navigator because it is accessible to faculty/staff and does not presuppose startup maturity. [107]
Programs: https://skandalaris.wustl.edu/programs/
Venture Development: https://skandalaris.wustl.edu/resource/venture-development/

Skandalaris Venture Competition. Must be indexed specifically as a **negative eligibility source**: current rules excluding WashU/university IP make it dangerous for a generic startup recommender to surface indiscriminately. [4]
Official: https://skandalaris.wustl.edu/program/skandalaris-venture-competition/

Needleman Program for Innovation & Commercialization — Services, Applications and Contact. These pages establish NPIC's therapeutic-development focus, current closed application status, university-wide PI eligibility during open windows, IND-oriented objective and central contact. [108]
Services: https://needlemanprogram.wustl.edu/services/
Applications: https://needlemanprogram.wustl.edu/application-resources/
Contact: https://needlemanprogram.wustl.edu/contact-us/

WashU ICTS — Research Forum, CTRFP and JIT. High-priority sources because innovation projects frequently need rigorous translational study design and preliminary evidence before they need a company. Current pages expose concrete eligibility, amounts, deadlines and contacts. [101]
Research Forum: https://icts.wustl.edu/research-services/research-development-program/research-forum-program/
CTRFP: https://icts.wustl.edu/funding/ctrfp-funding-program/
JIT: https://icts.wustl.edu/funding/just-in-time-jit/

Hope Center for Neurological Disorders — Pilot Projects. Neuroscience-specific source for translational pilots and membership eligibility. [28]
Official: https://hopecenter.wustl.edu/funding-awards/pilot-projects/

WashU Neurotech Hub. Departmentally relevant technical-development front door, especially for instrumentation, engineering, computation and prototyping before the commercial pathway is known. [27]
Official: https://neurotechhub.wustl.edu/

VeritaScience / Deerfield–WashU collaboration. Primary WashU announcement documents the ten-year, up-to-$130M partnership, IND-readiness development model and possible startup support. [36]
Official WashU source: https://source.washu.edu/2024/01/washington-university-deerfield-management-launch-veritascience-to-drive-drug-discovery/

Bristol Myers Squibb–WashU neuroscience collaboration. Important current partner source because it combines translational neuroscience funding with trainee placements and has an explicitly named business-development contact. [38]
Official: https://medicine.washu.edu/news/washu-announces-new-academic-industry-collaboration-with-bristol-myers-squibb/

BioSTL / BioGenerator Ventures. Primary regional source for life-science company formation, early capital, expert support, laboratory space and investor connections. [41]
Official: https://www.biostl.org/what-we-do/biogenerator

Cortex SQ1 Ignite. Primary source for low-friction concept-stage entrepreneurship training, with current cohort structure and costs. [45]
Official: https://www.cortexstl.org/learn/entrepreneur-training/sq1-ignite

Arch Grants Startup Competition. High-priority source because its attractive non-dilutive funding comes with significant company, founder and location requirements; the page also carries current-cycle status. [5]
Official: https://archgrants.org/programs/startup-competition/

Missouri Technology Corporation IDEA Fund. Primary state source for startup equity/co-investment tracks, current award levels and matching-capital structure. [109]
Official: https://www.missouritechnology.com/venture-capital-investments/mtc-idea-fund/

Missouri SBDC SBIR/STTR / FAST support. Best local public source identified for practical federal small-business grant assistance. [50]
Official: https://sbdc.missouri.edu/programs/technology/funding

NIH SEED — SBIR/STTR funding opportunities and I-Corps at NIH. These should be the authoritative federal sources for current small-business NOFOs, application cycles and commercialization education; do not rely on static WashU summaries for current federal eligibility. [110]
SBIR/STTR: https://seed.nih.gov/small-business-funding/find-funding/sbir-sttr-funding-opportunities
I-Corps: https://seed.nih.gov/I-Corps-at-NIH

NCATS Small Business Resources. Primary source for translational-science-focused small-business funding fit and program contact. [61]
Official: https://ncats.nih.gov/funding/small-business-programs/resources-applicants

NINDS Translational Devices and Small Business Program. Particularly important for Neuroscience because NINDS explicitly supports translational neural/device development and maintains neuroscience-specific small-business routes. [62]
Devices: https://www.ninds.nih.gov/current-research/research-funded-ninds/translational-research/translational-devices
Small Business: https://www.ninds.nih.gov/funding/ninds-small-business-program

NIA Small Business Programs. High-value specialty source for Alzheimer's disease, ADRD and aging innovations. [63]
Official: https://www.nia.nih.gov/research/sbir/about-nia-small-business-funding

Regional life-science investors — Cultivation Capital, RiverVest and Osage University Partners. These are best treated as downstream financing/network cards, not general investigator services. Cultivation explicitly targets life-science/health-tech categories; RiverVest specializes in building biopharma/device companies; OUP specializes in science-driven university-associated startups. [111]
Cultivation: https://cultivationcapital.com/strategies/life-sciences-health-technology/

RiverVest: https://rivervest.com/
OUP: https://oup.vc/

Taken together, these sources support an app that is substantially more useful than a static innovation directory. The most defensible design is an **investigator-centered decision engine with a small permanent state graph and a continuously maintained resource layer**. The graph—problem → evidence → external relevance → transfer strategy → de-risking → deployment → impact—should remain relatively stable. Program funding amounts, deadlines, contacts and eligibility should be treated as volatile data. WashU's FY26 innovation activity—316 disclosures, 85 U.S. patents issued and 12 new IP-based startups—shows that the institutional machinery is active; the navigator's opportunity is to make that machinery legible to the much larger population of investigators who have not yet decided whether their discovery belongs in it. [9]

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[1] [9] [105] WashU Innovation - Home
https://innovation.washu.edu/?utm_source=chatgpt.com

[2] [8] [66] Our Process
https://innovation.washu.edu/our-process/?utm_source=chatgpt.com

[3] [15] [16] [65] [73] [97] [99] Gap Fund | Office of Technology Management/Tech Transfer
https://otm.wustl.edu/disclose-inventions/gap-fund/?utm_source=chatgpt.com

[4] [95] Skandalaris Venture Competition - Skandalaris Center - WashU
https://skandalaris.wustl.edu/program/skandalaris-venture-competition/?utm_source=chatgpt.com

[5] Startup Competition
https://archgrants.org/programs/startup-competition/?utm_source=chatgpt.com

[6] [56] [58] [77] [88] [91] [103] [110] SBIR and STTR Funding Opportunities
https://seed.nih.gov/small-business-funding/find-funding/sbir-sttr-funding-opportunities?utm_source=chatgpt.com

[7] [34] [74] [81] [83] [84] [90] [94] [96] Application Resources
https://needlemanprogram.wustl.edu/application-resources/?utm_source=chatgpt.com

[10] [67] [75] [85] [100] Licensing Process
https://otm.wustl.edu/disclose-inventions/licensing-process/?utm_source=chatgpt.com

[11] Tech Transfer Contact by WashU Department
https://otm.wustl.edu/disclose-inventions/otm-contact-by-washu-department/?utm_source=chatgpt.com

[12] Lifeline Technologies
https://otm.wustl.edu/items/lifeline-technologies/?utm_source=chatgpt.com

[13] [14] [71] [93] Domain Expert Program (DEP)
https://otm.wustl.edu/items/domain-expert-program-dep/?utm_source=chatgpt.com

[17] [106] Experts in Residence
https://otm.wustl.edu/items/experts-in-residence/?utm_source=chatgpt.com

[18] [19] [20] [76] [87] Entrepreneur in Residence
https://otm.wustl.edu/items/entrepreneur-in-residence/?utm_source=chatgpt.com

21 22 82 Quick Start License | Office of Technology Management/Tech Transfer
https://otm.wustl.edu/disclose-inventions/quick-start-license/?utm_source=chatgpt.com

23 Venture Development - St. Louis - Skandalaris Center - WashU
https://skandalaris.wustl.edu/resource/venture-development/?utm_source=chatgpt.com

24 107 Home - Skandalaris Center for Interdisciplinary ... - WashU
https://skandalaris.wustl.edu/?utm_source=chatgpt.com

25 In-Residence Program - St. Louis - Skandalaris Center - WashU
https://skandalaris.wustl.edu/resource/in-residence-program/?utm_source=chatgpt.com

26 Programs - Skandalaris Center for Interdisciplinary Innovation ...
https://skandalaris.wustl.edu/programs/?utm_source=chatgpt.com

27 40 68 69 79 About Us
https://neurotechhub.wustl.edu/about-us/?utm_source=chatgpt.com

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